All the knives, spears and arrowheads discovered—presumed by some scholars to be used for hunting—could have been used against other groups of humans (one seal shows two men spearing each other while a woman, or a goddess, stands in the middle holding their free hands). There may well have been conflicts over fertile farmland, forests, water, taxation or certain resources that may not have been as plentiful as presumed. Still, the lack of loud and clear indicators of war or standing armies, so commonplace in other civilizations, is a striking feature of the Harappan Civilization.

Further, Harappan cities have not revealed monumental, or even humble, temple structures, a great puzzle for scholars. There aren't any equivalents of the temples and pyramids of ancient Egypt or the ziggurats of Mesopotamia. Some say the Great Bath of Mohenjo-Daro had a religious purpose but this is highly speculative. Or perhaps the Harappans built religious shrines and large sculptures from perishable materials like wood. In any case, while there are hints, we have no clear sense of Harappan gods and rituals, or whether they had any temples or priests.

Scholars have offered divergent interpretations of seals with possible religious content: a handsome seven-inch sculpture of a man named 'priest-king', who could well have been an aristocrat; a seal named 'proto-Shiva' that depicts a multi-headed, seated figure in a yoga-like pose, one of 'several other yogi images in the corpus of Mature Harappan materials';[25] another seal that shows a female (deity?) standing under a Bodhi tree with its heart-shaped leaves, a figure kneeling before her in supplication and seven standing figures watching them; other seals that depict mysterious objects and rituals before a unicorn; the swastika motif appears often; some female figurines have a paste-like substance along the middle parting of their hair; a stone object in the shape of a phallus has been identified; two terracotta male figurines have erections; a small terracotta object in Kalibangan resembles the familiar Shiva lingam.

All this is very tantalizing. There can be little doubt about cultural continuities. Harappan beliefs clearly shaped later religions of the Axial Age in the subcontinent. Quite possibly, Indian ideas of meditation and even renunciation have Harappan origins. But it's difficult to draw firm conclusions about this, or about what the Harappans themselves believed, at least until the script begins to speak. Scepticism is essential: The deciphered